

Wrong with AMU?

COUNTERPOINT

It began with violence. The V-C's Lodge was set ablaze. There were reports that criminal elements frequented the campus and even stayed in hostels.

A fact-finding committee is already at work to probe the charges.

An expert committee is already preparing a master plan for the restoration of the heritage buildings in the AMU campus and upgrading the existing infrastructure.

It was a well thought decision of the University court, the executive council and the academic council to establish five AMU centres at Bhopal, Kishanganj, Murshidabad, Mallappuram and Pune. AMU has already submitted to the Human Resource Development Ministry a proposal for the establishment of five centres at a total investment of Rs 2,000 crore, with an estimated cost of Rs 400 crore per centre.

VICE-CHANCELLOR
ABDUL AZIS

Even critics like Islam agree that the decline started in the 1990s when academics surrendered before the authorities. By 1992-93, *goondaism* on the campus in the name of student unions had crossed all limits. Taking advantage of this, successive v-cs stopped all academic activities; even permission to hold seminars was denied. When Azis took over in June 2007, the turbulence was at its height and he felt an iron fist was the only answer. Abrar says the decision to

AMU took action against Siras because according to its statutes what he had been indulging in was gross misconduct.

Teachers should remember they are role models.

RAHAT ABRAR,
PRO



CCTVs are aimed at creating an atmosphere of suspicion and fear among students and teachers. Their voices are suppressed so they can't demand better facilities.

JAMSHED SIDDIQUI,
Secretary, AMUTA



By turning the campus into a police state, authorities have caged the soul of AMU. How can students achieve excellence without academic freedom and free exchange of views?

ELIZABETH MARIAM,
Student



Naseem Ahmad had to resign just before completing his tenure. As National Convener of the Aligarh Movement Foundation, Omar Peerzada says AMU, the grand institution of Muslim dreams, has been lying wounded for decades. What's worse, he points out, it's a "self-inflicted wound". In the past too, hostels have been attacked by a group carrying AK-47s, rifles and *kattas*; teachers have been assaulted by students; Registrar Faizam Mustafa's house was attacked and his family providentially escaped. Then there was the murder of Manzar Safi within the hostel room and so on.

But AMU's tragedy lies in its inception. Parcham Party of India Chief Salim Peerzada, an AMU alumnus, traces the history to the 1920 Act through which it was upgraded as a university having a distinct minority character with the teaching of theology as a must. Since the Congress was against this, in 1951 the teaching of theology was made optional. In 1965, the Centre through an ordinance annulled the past act and took over all powers. This led to a movement with Muslims being made to think that Congress had destroyed the last sign of Muslim nationalism. Indira Gandhi promised to restore AMU's minority character and the act in 1972 took away its autonomy. But in 1981 through an amendment, the government restored its position "to promote the educational and cultural advancement of Muslims of India".

At the heart of the problem is the 1981 Act whose Section 19(3) gives emergency powers to the v-c. According to a study by researcher Jasim Mohammad, one v-c used this emergency power 2,755 times while v-c Hamid Ansari used it 1,823 times and Mehmood-ur-Rahman used it 3,906 times. The v-c's emergency powers had made the administration autocratic and created a huge chasm with the students-teachers community. But until AMU is given a drastic shakedown, the police raj ends and academic freedom is restored, no emergency powers will be enough to implement p academic agenda. ■

install electronic surveillance was taken after the burning down of the v-c's Lodge. "The Executive Council decided to revamp security on the campus and found that cameras were already installed in Delhi University and in Delhi to keep a check on sexual harassment. The CCTVs are only aimed at campus roads, halls and hostel gates."

Between 1995 and 2000, when Mahmood-ur-Rehman was the v-c, four closures took place. IAS officer